



BEFORE

The Soviet Union was economically stagnant and corrupt during the 1960s and 1970s.

THE ERA OF STAGNATION

In 1964, **Leonid Brezhnev** succeeded **Nikita Khrushchev** as leader of the USSR and stayed in office until 1982. Under his leadership the **economy stagnated**, and slow growth was experienced in some sectors. There were **perennial shortages** of manufactured goods and food, and reduced consumer options caused frustration among the people.



LEONID BREZHNEV

DOUBLE STANDARDS IN THE SYSTEM

Although all Soviet citizens were officially equal, in reality, **the system was corruptible**; bribes secured better jobs or housing and **senior communist party officials** had access to **privileges** unattainable by ordinary people.

Perestroika

When Mikhail Gorbachev became leader of the Soviet Union in 1985, he acknowledged faults within the communist system and set out a new plan for political reform—**perestroika**. He aimed to renew the Soviet Union, but **perestroika** resulted in changes that altered the country beyond recognition.

Gorbachev was a child of communism, the first leader of the USSR to have been born after the revolution (see pp.376–77). He did not question Lenin's view that communism could only be achieved through disciplined, central organization, but aimed to address failings elsewhere in the Soviet system. Through *perestroika* (restructuring) he attempted to streamline the Soviet Communist Party (CPSU). Gorbachev also recognized that state repression of those who criticized the CPSU had created problems in Soviet society. He pledged a new openness—*glasnost*—

in political affairs; exiled intellectuals were allowed to return and political debate was encouraged.

At first, *glasnost* and *perestroika* were met with general excitement, although there was resistance from those who resented reforms aimed at reducing their power and privilege. By the end of 1986, however, with the economic situation worsening, Gorbachev's talk of progress began to sound like an empty promise. His economic reforms were too cautious. He introduced limited rights for private enterprise, but most production remained under control of the state, where restructuring

failed to stimulate growth. By 1987, *perestroika* had led to longer food queues and food shortages.

Glasnost had enabled all Soviet citizens to express their dissatisfaction with both the CPSU and the Soviet system. In 1988, Gorbachev began to face internal resistance as nationalist movements in Kazakhstan, Armenia, Azerbaijan, and the Baltic States (Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania) demanded independence from the centralized Soviet government.

In 1989, hoping that the Soviet people would accept a new "humane communism," Gorbachev allowed